

The Sociology of Relationships and Family Policy

2026-27



What You Will Learn in This Unit

In this unit, we will explore what shapes our most personal relationships – including but not limited to gender, policy, work, and inequality.

By taking this unit, you will:

- Think critically about how gender roles, welfare systems, and workplace expectations affect care and family life.
- Learn how policies in the UK and other countries shape experiences of and inequalities in family life, employment, income, and wellbeing.

By the end of the unit, you'll be able to:

- Use sociological and feminist theories to understand family life, parenting, and work.
- Analyse real policies and workplace practices and what they mean for gender equality.
- Critically assess different measures of inequality and what they (do not) tell us.
- Compare how different countries support (or fail to support) families and care work.
- Reflect on your own assumptions about choice, fairness, and the 'private' sphere.
- Confidently write critical essays using theory and evidence.

Recommended Background Reading and Other Resources

If you would like to explore some of the key themes before the unit begins – or deepen your understanding as we go – here are a few good starting points:

- The Second Shift: Working Families and the Revolution at Home (available online through the library)
- [Journal of Marriage and Family](#)
- [Journal of European Social Policy](#)
- The Palgrave Handbook of Family Policy (available online through the library)

Here are also some useful resources for statistics or policy examples, which you might want to consult and draw on in class prep tasks and for your revision:

- [OECD Family Database](#) provides cross-national indicators on family outcomes and family policies across the OECD countries.
- [21st International Review on Leave Policies and Related Research 2025](#) gives lots of detail about early-years family policies across different countries.
- [Institute for Fiscal Studies](#) often provides analysis of UK family policies and trends.

Some other great non-academic resources include:

- [MissPerceived podcast](#)
- [Motherhood Sessions podcast](#)
- [BBC Worklife](#)

Teaching and Assessment

The unit includes **ten taught sessions**: 3 x 50-minute sessions and 7 x 1hr 50-minute sessions. Sessions are a mix of lecture content, discussion, and applied activities.

The assessment for this unit is **100% exam**.

LECTURES

Week 1 – Introduction to the Unit

Week 2 – Gender and the Division of Unpaid Work

Intended learning outcomes	By the end of the session, you will be able to: • Identify different forms of unpaid labour, including the distinction between physical and cognitive labour, and how it is divided unequally between men and women. • Compare and contrast sociological theories explaining the persistence of the gendered division of unpaid work. • Apply sociological theories to different forms of unpaid labour and evaluate their explanatory strengths and limitations.
Core readings	Zhou, M., Wu, Y., & Kan, M.-Y. (2025). Using Time Use Data to Investigate Gender Inequalities: Enduring Patterns and New Dimensions. <i>Sociology Compass</i>, 19(11). https://doi.org/10.1111/soc4.70132 Weeks, A.C., Kowalewska, H., & Ruppanner, L. (2025). Take a Load Off? Not for Mothers: Gender, Cognitive Labour, and the Limits of Time and Money. <i>Socius</i>, 11. https://doi.org/10.1177/23780231251384527
Bonus readings	Daminger, A. (2019). The Cognitive Dimension of Household Labour. <i>American Sociological Review</i>, 84(4), 609-633. https://doi.org/10.1177/0003122419859007 Hipp, L., Leshchenko, O., & Sauermann, A. (2026). Who Shoulders the Mental Work? Evidence on the Distribution of Mental Work in Different-Sex Couples in Germany. <i>Social Problems</i>. https://doi.org/10.1093/socpro/spaf080 Vettoretto E., Minello, A., Ortensi, L.E., & Tosi, F. (2026) Understanding the Dimensions of Mental Labour: The Invisible Load of Italian Mothers. <i>Frontiers in Sociology</i>, 10(2025). https://doi.org/10.3389/fsoc.2025.1683261 Geist, C. & Ruppanner, L. (2018) Mission Impossible? New Housework Theories for Changing Families. <i>Journal of Family Theory & Review</i>, 10(1), 242-262. https://doi.org/10.1111/jftr.12245 Duffy, M. (2005). Reproducing Labour Inequalities: Challenges for Feminists Conceptualising Care at the Intersections of Gender, Race, and Class. <i>Gender & Society</i>, 19(1), 66-82. https://doi.org/10.1177/0891243204269499

Week 3 – Gender Inequalities in Paid Work: Concepts and Measures

Intended learning outcomes	By the end of the session, you will be able to: - Define and distinguish key indicators of gender inequality in paid work, including employment participation, working hours, occupational segregation and gender pay gaps. - Critically assess what these different indicators tell us about gender equality, and what they may conceal.
Core readings	Hipp, L. & Kelley, K. (2025). Gender Differences in Paid Work Over Time: Developments and Challenges in Comparative Research. <i>PLoS One</i>, 20(5): e0322871. https://pmc.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/articles/PMC12077737/ Kowalewska, H. (2024). Gendered Employment Patterns: Women's Labour Market Outcomes Across 24 Countries. <i>Journal of European Social Policy</i>, 33(2), 151-168. https://doi.org/10.1177/09589287221148336
Bonus readings	Olivetti, C. & Petrongolo, B. (2016). The Evolution of Gender Gaps in Industrialised Countries. <i>Annual Review of Economics</i>, 8, 405-434. https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-economics-080614-115329 Carranza, E., Das, S., & Kotikula, A. (2019). <i>Gender-Based Employment Segregation: Understanding Causes and Policy Interventions</i>. Jobs Working Paper No. 26. Washington, DC: World Bank. https://doi.org/10.1596/31510 England, P. (2010) The Gender Revolution: Uneven and Stalled. <i>Gender and Society</i>, 24(2), 149–166. http://www.jstor.org/stable/27809263

Week 4 – Motherhood Penalties and Fatherhood Bonuses

Please note we will reserve the last ~30 mins of the session to talk about the assessment.

Intended learning outcomes	By the end of the session, you will be able to: - Identify and critically assess the mechanisms underpinning the “motherhood penalty” and “fatherhood bonus”. - Reflect on how other intersections of identity and workplace culture shape employment outcomes for mothers and fathers. - Identify the components of a coherent, well-argued exam response.
Core readings	Correll, S. J., Benard, S., & Paik, I. (2007). Getting a Job: Is There a Motherhood Penalty? <i>American Journal of Sociology</i> 112(5), 1297-1339. https://www.jstor.org/stable/10.1086/511799 Williams, J. C., Blair-Loy, M., & Berdahl, J. L. (2013). Cultural Schemas, Social Class, and the Flexibility Stigma. <i>Journal of Social Issues</i>, 69(2), 209-234. https://doi.org/10.1111/josi.12012
Bonus readings	Glauber, R. (2018). Trends in the Motherhood Wage Penalty and Fatherhood Wage Premium for Low, Middle, and High

	Earners. <i>Demography</i> 55(5), 1663-1680. https://doi.org/10.1007/s13524-018-0712-5 Chung, H. & Seo, H. (2024). Flexibility Stigma Across Europe: How National Contexts Can Shift the Extent to which Flexible Workers are Stigmatised. <i>Social Indicators Research</i>, 174(2024), 945–965. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11205-024-03420-w Gillies, V. (2007). <i>Marginalised Mothers: Exploring Working-Class Experiences of Parenting</i>. London: Routledge. Petts, R.J., Kaufman, G., & Mize, T.D. (2023). Parental Leave-Taking and Perceptions of Workers as Good Parents. <i>Journal of Marriage and Family</i> 85(1), 261-279. https://doi.org/10.1111/jomf.12875
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Week 5 – READING WEEK: No Lecture

Week 6 – Female-Breadwinner Couples: Challenging Gender Norms?

Intended learning outcomes	By the end of the session, you will be able to: • Describe patterns, drivers and variation in female breadwinning across high-income countries. • Analyse how female breadwinning can challenge and reinforce gender norms around paid work, unpaid work and family roles. Critically evaluate economic-disadvantage and gender-norm explanations for lower wellbeing and relationship satisfaction among female-breadwinner couples.
Core readings	Chesley, N. (2016). What Does It Mean to Be a “Breadwinner” Mother? <i>Journal of Family Issues</i>, 38(18), 2594-2619. https://doi.org/10.1177/0192513X16676857 Demantas, I., & Myers, K. (2015). “Step Up and Be a Man in a Different Manner”: Unemployed Men Reframing Masculinity. <i>The Sociological Quarterly</i>, 56(4), 640–664. https://doi.org/10.1111/tsq.12099
Bonus readings	Pinho, M., & Gaunt, R. (2019). Doing and Undoing Gender in Male Carer/Female Breadwinner families. <i>Community, Work & Family</i>, 24(3), 315–330. https://doi.org/10.1080/13668803.2019.1681940 Sánchez-Mira, N. (2024). (Un)doing Gender in Female Breadwinner Households: Gender Relations and Structural Change. <i>Gender, Work & Organization</i>, 31(4), 1196–1213. https://doi.org/10.1111/gwao.12775 Dunn, M. G., Rochlen, A. B., & O’Brien, K. M. (2011). Employee, Mother, and Partner: An Exploratory Investigation of Working Women With Stay-at-Home Fathers. <i>Journal of Career Development</i>, 40(1), 3-22. https://doi.org/10.1177/0894845311401744

	Van der Lippe, T., Treas, J., & Norbutas, L. (2017). Unemployment and the Division of Housework in Europe. <i>Work, Employment and Society</i> , 32(4), 650-669. https://doi.org/10.1177/0950017017690495
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Week 7 – Family Policy in the UK

Intended learning outcomes	By the end of the session, you will be able to: - Analyse how ideas about work, welfare and family responsibility have shaped UK family policy since the 1990s. - Critically assess the assumptions and consequences of the two-child limit and evaluate Labour's decision to abolish it. - Critically evaluate how the aims and design of Universal Credit affect family wellbeing.
Core readings	Stewart, K., Andersen, K., Patrick, R., Reader, M., & Reeves, A. (2025). Does Reducing Child Benefits Mean Parents Work More? A Mixed-Methods Study of the Labour Market Effects of the United Kingdom's "Two-Child Limit". <i>Social Service Review</i>, 99(1), 3-42. https://doi.org/10.1086/734071 Pearce, N., & Kelly, G. (2025) The Recent History and Future Prospects of the UK Welfare State, <i>Oxford Review of Economic Policy</i>, 41(1), 28–40. https://doi.org/10.1093/oxrep/graf004
Bonus readings	Patrick, R. & Andersen, K. (2023). The Two-Child Limit and Fertility Decision Making: When Policy Narratives and Lived Experiences Collide. <i>Social Policy & Administration</i>, 57(5), 580–595. https://doi.org/10.1111/spol.12877 Gillies, V., & Edwards, R. (2024). 'The Conservatives, Family Policy and the Data Revolution.' In: Bochel, H., & Powell, M. (eds.) <i>The Conservative Governments and Social Policy</i>, Bristol: Bristol University Press. Millar, J., & Bennett, F. (2017). Universal Credit: Assumptions, Contradictions and Virtual Reality. <i>Social Policy and Society</i>, 16(2), 169–182. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1474746416000154 Fei, S., & Zhang, C. (2025). When Can Government Paternalist Interventions Be Justified? Welfare-to-Work and Interference Intentions. <i>Social Policy and Society</i>, 1–14. https://doi.org/10.1017/S1474746424000666 Wood, M., & Bennett, F. (2023). Parenting in the Pandemic: Exploring the Experiences of Families with Children on Universal Credit Before and During the COVID-19 Pandemic. <i>Families, Relationships and Societies</i>, 12(2), 163-179. https://doi.org/10.1332/204674321X16528527479429 Chzhen, Y. & Bradshaw, J. (2025). The Two-Child Limit and Child Poverty in the United Kingdom. <i>International Journal of Social Welfare</i>, 34(1), e12642. https://doi.org/10.1111/ijsw.12642

Week 8 – Family Policy in Comparative Perspective

Please note we will reserve the last ~20 mins of the session to talk about the assessment.

Intended learning outcomes	By the end of the session, you will be able to: • Compare family policies across countries using the concepts of familisation and defamilialisation. • Critically assess how different features and combinations of family policies shape gender equality and parents' ability to combine paid work and care. • Analyse an exam-style comparative policy question and identify how to construct a strong argument.
Core readings	Nieuwenhuis, R., & Van Lancker, W. (eds.) (2020) <i>The Palgrave Handbook of Family Policy</i>. Cham: Palgrave Macmillan – especially Chapters 9 and 11 Filetti, F.D. (2025) Familialization, De-familialization, and Family Policy Change in High-Income Countries. <i>Social Politics: International Studies in Gender, State & Society</i>. https://doi.org/10.1093/sp/jxaf052
Bonus readings	Lohmann, H., & Zagel, H. (2016). Family Policy in Comparative Perspective: The Concepts and Measurement of Familization and Defamilization. <i>Journal of European Social Policy</i>, 26(1), 48-65. https://doi.org/10.1177/0958928715621712 Misra, J., Budig, M.J., & Moller, S. (2007). Reconciliation Policies and the Effects of Motherhood on Employment, Earnings and Poverty. <i>Journal of Comparative Policy Analysis</i> 9(2), 135-155. https://doi.org/10.1080/13876980701311588 Hegewisch, A., & Gornick, J.C. (2011). The Impact of Work-Family Policies on Women's Employment: A Review of Research from OECD Countries. <i>Community, Work and Family</i>, 14(2), 119-138. https://doi.org/10.1080/13668803.2011.571395

Week 9 – Policy Spotlight: Shared Parental Leave

Intended learning outcomes	By the end of the session, you will be able to: • Outline the UK's system of Shared Parental Leave. • Explain why take up of Shared Parental Leave by UK fathers has been so low. • Debate approaches to increase men's participation in parental leave, drawing on academic evidence and experiences from other countries.
Core readings	Clifton-Sprigg, J., Fichera, E., Kaya, E., & Jones, M. (2025). Fathers Taking Leave: Evaluating the Impact of Shared Parental Leave in the United Kingdom. <i>Fiscal Studies</i>, 46(3), 399–410. https://doi.org/10.1111/1475-5890.70000

	Atkinson, J. (2025). Reconciling the Ideal Worker Norm and Involved Fatherhood: New Fathers' Experiences of Requesting Shared Parental Leave in UK Organisations. <i>Community, Work & Family</i>, 28(3), 363–386. https://doi.org/10.1080/13668803.2023.2274276
Bonus readings	Tarrant, A., Ladlow, L., Koslowski, A., Churchill, H., Finch, N., & Hamilton, P. (2026). Appraising the UK Labour Government's Early Approach to Reforming Parental Leave: The Limits of Incrementalism for Gender Equality and Social Inclusion. <i>Social Policy and Society</i>, 25(2), 397-410. https://doi.org/10.1017/S147474642610133X Twamley, K., & Schober, P. (2019). Shared Parental Leave: Exploring Variations in Attitudes, Eligibility, Knowledge and Take-up Intentions of Expectant Mothers in London. <i>Journal of Social Policy</i>, 48(2), 387-407. https://doi.org/10.1017/S0047279418000557 Duvander, A.-Z. & Fahlén, S. (2025). To Take Leave or Not to Take and How Long to Take? A Study on Swedish Fathers' Parental Leave Use. <i>Journal of Family Issues</i>, 46(6), 1050-1078. https://doi.org/10.1177/0192513X251329594 Wood J., Marynissen L., & Van Gasse D. (2023). When is it About the Money? Relative Wages and Fathers' Parental Leave Decisions. <i>Population Research and Policy Review</i>, 42(6), 93. https://doi.org/10.1007/s11113-023-09837-4 Myers, K., and Demantas, I. (2016) Breadwinning and Bread-Losing: Exploring Opportunities to Rework Manhood. <i>Sociology Compass</i>, 10, 1119–1130. https://doi.org/10.1111/soc4.12437. Holloway, V. G., Dhensa-Kahlon, R. K., & Alexandra Beauregard, T. (2026). Daddy's (Not) Home: Work and Gender-Related Factors in Men's Attitudes Towards Shared Parental Leave. <i>Community, Work & Family</i>, 29(1), 51–71. https://doi.org/10.1080/13668803.2024.2345872

Week 10 – Mock Exam/Exam Drop-in

Week 11 – Revision Session